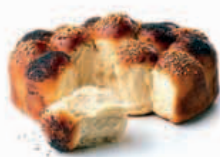


ULM GERMANY

Swabian Noodles in Ulm

Most visitors to the pretty city of Ulm are drawn there to see the world's tallest church spire, a staggering piece of Gothic architecture that demonstrates the city's prosperity in medieval times. But this city – the birthplace of Albert Einstein – is full of surprises, not least the fine cuisine of the Swabian Alp region and its Italianate little egg noodles known as *Spätzle*.



On the banks of the Danube River sits Ulm, a sleepy old city that was first mentioned as a royal domain in 854 and became

rich in the Middle Ages through the linen trade. Its magnificent church dates back to 1377, though its ambitious spire wasn't completed for another 500 years. On clear days even the Alps are visible from the top, making it well worth the long climb. The streets leading downhill from the minster to the Danube are scattered with fascinating buildings, from the attractive jumble of half-timbered 15th-century houses in the Fishermen's Quarter to the Rathaus (town hall) with its historic frescoes. The Eagle's Bastion, a nondescript 17th-century building by the river, is worthy of a visit in memory of the "tailor of Ulm," who attempted the first recorded (unsuccessful) flight from here in 1811.

The city's symbol is the sparrow. The legendary tale relates that while building the church, workmen were unable to get one of the huge wooden beams through the city gates, until they were inspired by the sight of a sparrow carrying a twig vertically in its beak.

The legend of the *Ulmer Spätzle* (sparrow of Ulm) was born. Interestingly, the city's best-loved dish, *Spätzle*, means "little sparrow," although no one is quite sure why; it may refer to the legend or to the *Spätzle*'s original hand-pressed shapes, evident in medieval drawings.

Spätzle are served at most of Ulm's restaurants and at all of its many, boisterous festivals. Shaped like tiny dumplings or thin ragged fingers of pasta, *Spätzle* are made from white wheat flour, egg, and milk dough, to which minced pork liver is sometimes added to make *Leberspätzle*. This dough is then either finely chopped, forced through holes in a strainer, or grated into boiling salted water where it is cooked until it surfaces.

As a standalone dish, *Spätzle* most commonly appear as *Käsespätzle* (in a cheese sauce) or as *Krautspätzle*, which includes sauerkraut, onion, butter, marjoram, and caraway. *Spätzle* also make an important appearance in the regional beef stew *Gaisburger Marsch*, along with chopped potatoes and butter-fried onions, but most often they simply take the place of potatoes or dumplings in traditional German meat dishes such as sauerbraten (see pp92–3).

Ulm Bread Museum

Bread had religious importance in Germany for many centuries as an offering in pagan rites. This explains the many shapes still available today: round flat loaves once represented the sun, while braided loaves symbolized shorn hair. A tradition also developed of shaping bread into nature's creations, such as horses, birds, deer, fish, or sheaves of wheat for special occasions. Ulm's **Museum der Brotkultur** (bread museum) confirms bread's historical importance with its staggering 25,000 related objects and books. Most Ulm bakeries offer a wonderful range of breads to admire and buy, spanning from coarse, dark, and slightly sweet rye pumpernickel to multigrain loaves sprinkled with poppy or sunflower seeds. Many end up in a simple evening meal; the German word for dinner, *Abendbrot*, literally means "evening bread."



Above The elaborately painted walls of the 14th-century Rathaus



The Best Places to Eat Spätzle

Zunfthaus der Schifflente moderate

Once the local guild headquarters for fishermen, this 15th-century half-timbered house is home to one of Ulm's oldest restaurants. Inside, stone floors with timeless, heavy wooden furniture set the perfect scene for traditional Swabian foods, many of which involve outstanding homemade *Spätzle*. Virtually the whole range of possibilities are here; among them the standard *Käsespätzle*, in its rich cheese sauce, and the fairly common *Linsen* (lentils) *mit Spätzle* and *Krautspätzle*. More unusual meal options include the *Zunfthausstöpfe*, with its creamy herb-heavy mushroom sauce; and the robust *Ulmer Pfännle*, in which pork kebabs are smothered in fiery pepper sauce. Often the most interesting choices are on the restaurant's seasonal menu, where delicious ingredients such as asparagus, chanterelle mushrooms, and venison are served with *Spätzle*. A good selection of local beers is on hand to provide the perfect accompaniment to this rustic fare. But be sure not to overindulge on the main courses, as the vanilla ice cream with hot figs is well worth leaving space for.

Fischergasse 31, Ulm; open 11 AM–midnight Mon–Sat; www.zunfthaus-ulm.de

Also in Ulm

If you'd rather have your *Spätzle* served with a gourmet twist, try charming **Zur Forelle** (www.zurforelle.com; *expensive*), which is also based in a 15th-century Fishermen's Quarter house. Its *Gaisburger Marsch* (Swabian beef stew) is particularly wonderful.

Also in Germany

Elsewhere in Swabia, in the venerable university town of Tübingen, the **Hotel am Schloss** (www.hotelam-schloss.de; *moderate*) is largely famous for its *Maultaschen* (Swabian ravioli) and fine views of the city, but it always serves great *Spätzle* too and isn't afraid to experiment with dishes such as venison pot roast with hazelnut *Spätzle*. While it's easy to find good *Spätzle* in Swabia, it's much harder elsewhere in Germany, particularly in the north, which makes Berlin's **s'Brätle** (+49 30 8862 7138; *moderate*) all the more valuable. Its range of southern German specialties include superb *Spätzle*.

Around the World

With many Swabians emigrating to North America, it's also possible to find good *Spätzle* there too. In Alameda, California, the **Speisekammer** (www.speisekammer.com; *moderate*) provides San Francisco's Bay Area with a *Käsespätzle* to be proud of. On the east coast, **Cafe Steinhof** (www.cafesteinhof.com; *inexpensive*) does a first-rate job of the same dish, even though it classifies itself as an Austrian restaurant.